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Sentencing Hearing Transcript

Hearing date: February 24, 2026 **Synthetic docket:** SYN-MDNC-25-CR-0328 **Public docket entry:** DE37 **Time and place:** 10:00 a.m., fictional Courtroom Three

THE CLERK: All rise. The fictional United States District Court for the Middle District of North Carolina is now in session, the Honorable Elara Venn presiding.

THE COURT: Please be seated. We are here in United States v. Mateo Serrano for sentencing on Count One. This transcript is a synthetic training record. Counsel, state your appearances.

MR. IVES: Bram Ives for the fictional United States.

MS. ARDEN: Celia Arden for Mateo Serrano, who is present beside me.

THE COURT: I have reviewed the plea materials, the final presentence report dated February 17, the sealed objection packet, both sentencing memoranda, and the public docket surrogates. The sole unresolved Guidelines objection concerns the proposed three-level adjustment under § 3B1.1(b). After deciding it, I will calculate the advisory range, hear sentencing argument, consider the statutory factors, and impose sentence. Does either side identify another unresolved objection?

MR. IVES: No, Your Honor.

MS. ARDEN: No. The defense preserves only the person-management objection.

Appearances and Preliminary Matters

THE COURT: Mr. Serrano, can you hear the proceeding and consult with Ms. Arden?

THE DEFENDANT: Yes, Your Honor.

THE COURT: Counsel, is there any reason we cannot proceed today?

MS. ARDEN: No. The defense has had adequate time to review the final report and addendum with Mr. Serrano.

MR. IVES: The government is ready.

THE COURT: The record reflects that the guilty plea was accepted on November 18, 2025. Today's date satisfies the applicable scheduling intervals following the plea and delivery of the draft report. No party seeks a continuance.

The court will refer to protected presentence information only at the level necessary to make findings. The underlying report and related submissions remain sealed. This open transcript will not include raw personal identifiers, transaction mechanics, account information, or reusable descriptions of wrongdoing.

MS. ARDEN: That procedure is acceptable. If a sensitive matter becomes necessary, I will ask to approach the category rather than state personal detail.

MR. IVES: Agreed.

THE COURT: Very well. The clerk may mark the appearances complete. We will begin with confirmation of the report process and then take the aggravating-role objection.

Plea and Offense Parameters

THE COURT: The conviction is for conspiracy to commit wire fraud under 18 U.S.C. §§ 1349 and 1343. The charged period began August 4 and ended November 2, 2025. The offense involved abstract false reimbursement claims for services not performed against Meridian Community Supply Cooperative. The stipulated aggregate loss and restitution amount is \$186,400.

MS. ARDEN: Those parameters are admitted. Mr. Serrano accepts knowing participation and does not withdraw or qualify his plea.

MR. IVES: The government agrees. No additional count is before the court.

THE COURT: The plea agreement did not resolve the aggravating-role adjustment. It did include an appeal waiver explained at the Rule 11 hearing, but that term does not alter my duty today to calculate the Guidelines correctly and consider § 3553(a).

There are exactly five criminally responsible participants for purposes of the disputed adjustment: Mateo Serrano, Alina Pared, Corin Bell, Darius Venn, and Nessa Holt. Is that count disputed?

MS. ARDEN: No. We dispute only whether Mr. Serrano managed or supervised Ms. Pared.

MR. IVES: That is also the government's understanding.

THE COURT: The record will reflect that narrow factual issue. No participant relationship beyond that one is offered as a basis for the adjustment.

Presentence Disclosure Schedule

THE COURT: The draft presentence report was disclosed January 9. The defense submitted its objection January 23. Probation issued a position January 30, and the government responded February 6. The final report and addendum were completed February 17. Both sides filed sentencing memoranda February 19.

MS. ARDEN: Those dates are accurate. We received the materials through the synthetic presentence channel and had a meaningful opportunity to respond.

MR. IVES: The government agrees with the chronology.

THE COURT: No party contends that a version was delivered late or that additional time is necessary. The PSR-related filings remain in protected volumes, with public category surrogates available on the docket. Their sealed treatment arises automatically from the rules governing presentence material; there was no separate motion requiring decision.

MS. ARDEN: Correct. The defense asks that confidential mitigation remain referred to by category in the open transcript.

THE COURT: I will do so. The final report contains the calculation alternatives presented in the addendum. I will not repeat confidential personal history unless essential to the reasons for sentence. This hearing record can state the facts, calculation, arguments, and ruling without disclosing any real or sensitive identifier.

Initial Guidelines Positions

THE COURT: Probation applies the 2025 Guidelines Manual because the offense continued through November 2, after that Manual's effective date. With the proposed three-level role adjustment, the total offense level is 20. With criminal history category I, the advisory imprisonment range is 33 to 41 months.

If the objection is sustained, the total offense level is 17 and the range is 24 to 30 months. Are there objections to any other component of either calculation?

MS. ARDEN: No. The defense agrees with the two alternatives and asks the court to use level 17.

MR. IVES: The government agrees with the arithmetic and requests level 20.

THE COURT: The dispute therefore changes the range but not criminal history, loss, restitution, or the acceptance adjustment already reflected in both paths. The Guidelines are advisory, yet I must resolve the factual objection before selecting a sentence.

The government bears the burden to prove the aggravating role by a preponderance. A role finding is person-focused. Management of property, assets, or activities alone would not establish that Serrano managed or supervised another participant. I will hear the defense first because it filed the objection, then the government and Probation.

Defense Presentation of the Role Objection

MS. ARDEN: The five-person count does not decide whether Mr. Serrano supervised anyone. The protected summaries show that Alina Pared made her own choice to participate, retained discretion over what she would do, and was not employed by or formally answerable to Mr. Serrano.

The government describes several communications as assignments. We describe them as requests among participants working toward a shared objective. Familiarity with a portion of the conspiracy and follow-up about a common task do not necessarily show authority over another person.

We rely on *United States v. Steffen*, 741 F.3d 411, 414–16, for the person-management requirement and the government's burden. We do not argue that management of assets should count. We argue that the interpersonal proof falls short.

Mr. Serrano admitted knowing participation, stipulated to the loss, and accepted restitution. Those admissions are substantial, but none includes an admission that Ms. Pared acted under his supervision. The plea deliberately left that question open. On this record, equal coordination is at least as plausible as hierarchy, so the preponderance standard is not satisfied.

Government Presentation on Role

MR. IVES: The government agrees that the adjustment must rest on management or supervision of a person. We rely only on Alina Pared and do not ask the court to infer a role from control of property or the defendant's general importance.

The protected exercise evidence shows a recurring sequence. Serrano selected Pared for a defined responsibility, communicated what result he expected, checked whether it was completed, and corrected a departure. Those interactions occurred more than once. Pared's freedom over minor details does not make every participant an equal.

We are not presenting transaction mechanics in open court. The abstract summaries permit the necessary inference without disclosing accounts, routes, credentials, or methods. Nor are we claiming Serrano directed Bell, Darius Venn, or Holt.

Under Steffen, formal employment and control of all activity are unnecessary if the defendant exercised managerial responsibility over at least one participant. The government's burden is a preponderance, not proof beyond a reasonable doubt. Viewed together, the pattern shows that Pared acted under Serrano's direction for her defined part. We ask the court to overrule the objection and add three levels under § 3B1.1(b).

Probation Officer's Explanation

THE COURT: Mr. Faye, without revealing personal-history material, explain the basis for retaining the adjustment.

MR. FAYE: The final report identifies five responsible participants and isolates the Pared relationship. I did not rely on property management. The protected material describes Serrano initiating Pared's defined responsibility, communicating expectations, monitoring completion, and addressing a deviation.

THE COURT: Did the final report treat a request by itself as supervision?

MR. FAYE: No. The recommendation rests on the combined sequence and recurrence. I also recorded the defense view that Pared could decline and acted with discretion.

THE COURT: Does the adjustment depend on Serrano supervising every participant?

MR. FAYE: No. The recommendation concerns only one person.

MS. ARDEN: And the report does not identify wages, formal authority, or power to compel Pared?

MR. FAYE: Correct. Those features are absent. My position is that the observed direction and follow-up nonetheless show managerial responsibility by a preponderance.

MR. IVES: No further questions.

THE COURT: The officer's explanation is received as an account of the report analysis, not as separate evidence beyond the protected record already disclosed to both parties.

Defense Reply on the Factual Inference

MS. ARDEN: The government's verbs assume the conclusion. Saying Serrano “selected” Pared or “corrected” her converts ambiguous exchanges into hierarchy. The underlying abstract record shows that Pared had already chosen to participate and retained independent judgment.

Follow-up among conspirators may demonstrate coordination and knowledge. It does not invariably demonstrate supervision. No protected summary states that Pared believed she was required to comply, that Serrano could replace or discipline her, or that he controlled her participation. The government bears the burden on the role relationship itself.

We also caution against using the five-person count twice. It satisfies one element of § 3B1.1(b), but the adjustment still requires a manager-or-supervisor finding. Serrano's admission that he knowingly joined the conspiracy does not fill that gap.

If the court finds the evidence evenly balanced, the adjustment cannot apply under the preponderance standard. The correct total offense level would then be 17. We ask for an express finding limited to Pared so the reasons do not imply management of the other three participants or an impermissible asset-based theory.

THE COURT: The requested limitation is understood.

Court's Questions Concerning Person Management

THE COURT: Mr. Ives, identify the feature that most clearly distinguishes direction from a request among equals.

MR. IVES: The repeated combination of defining Pared's responsibility, monitoring her completion, and instructing her to correct a departure. We rely on the relationship across those events, not a single word.

THE COURT: Ms. Arden, does Serrano dispute that he communicated the expected result?

MS. ARDEN: He disputes that the communication carried authority. Participants may agree on a shared result without one managing another.

THE COURT: Mr. Faye, did the report infer supervision from ownership of information or resources?

MR. FAYE: No. The analysis is confined to interpersonal direction.

THE COURT: The court has not received evidence that Serrano employed Pared, threatened her, or controlled all details. Those absences are relevant but not necessarily dispositive. Conversely, knowledge and coordination alone would not suffice.

I must determine the most likely characterization of the protected sequence. The parties agree on what legal question governs, and their disagreement concerns the inference from fictional facts already disclosed. I am prepared to rule without repeating operational details in open court. Does either side need to add authority existing as of today?

MS. ARDEN: No.

MR. IVES: No, Your Honor.

Ruling on the Aggravating-Role Objection

THE COURT: The objection is overruled. I find by a preponderance that Serrano managed or supervised Alina Pared for a defined portion of the conspiracy. The finding rests on the repeated sequence in which he identified her responsibility, communicated the intended result, monitored completion, and directed correction when the performance departed from that result.

I have considered Pared's discretion, absence of formal employment, and ability to decline. Those facts limit the scope of the relationship, but they do not outweigh the pattern of direction and follow-up in this record. The government has shown more than mutual exchange among equal participants.

The finding concerns Pared alone. I do not find that Serrano managed Corin Bell, Darius Venn, or Nessa Holt. I also do not rely on management of assets, property, or activities standing alone. The numerical predicate is satisfied because the criminal activity involved exactly five responsible participants.

The three-level adjustment under § 3B1.1(b) applies. This is a sentencing factual finding based on the synthetic protected record, not a description of transaction mechanics. The clerk should reflect that the January 23 objection is overruled for the reasons stated here and in the separate public order.

Final Advisory Calculation

THE COURT: With the role ruling, the total offense level is 20. Serrano remains in criminal history category I. The advisory imprisonment range is 33 to 41 months. Without the three levels, the alternative would have been level 17 and 24 to 30 months, but that is not the adopted calculation.

Restitution is stipulated at \$186,400. The mandatory assessment on Count One is \$100. The parties' memoranda agree that no fine should be imposed because resources should be directed to restitution. The authorized supervised-release range permits the three-year term each side has addressed.

MS. ARDEN: We preserve the role objection and our request for 24 months, including as a variance from the adopted range.

MR. IVES: The government requests 36 months and three years of supervision.

THE COURT: The Guidelines are the starting point, not the final command. I will hear argument under § 3553(a), including mitigation and the competing sentence requests. Counsel should continue to use general categories for protected personal information. After argument, I will explain the sentence in public terms sufficient for review without reproducing sealed material.

Defense Sentencing Argument

MS. ARDEN: The defense asks for 24 months. Mr. Serrano accepts that a custodial sentence is warranted. He knowingly participated for roughly three months, stipulated to the full loss, pleaded guilty, and has never tried to shift his responsibility to Pared or anyone else.

The requested term is the low end of the range that would apply without the disputed adjustment. If the court maintains level 20, the same term is warranted as a variance. The role finding is narrow: no formal authority, threats, violence, or direction of the conspiracy as a whole. That limited relationship should not define the entire sentence.

Criminal history category I, early acceptance, structured treatment, steady lawful work, and recurring caregiving duties all support a lower term. Restitution and supervision will impose ongoing accountability after custody. A 24-month sentence is substantial in this defendant's life and adequately serves deterrence.

I will discuss mitigation by category to preserve confidentiality. Mr. Serrano has also prepared remarks addressing remorse and the changes he has begun. Counsel's submission cannot convey those matters in quite the same way as his own voice.

Defense Mitigation: Remorse and Treatment

MS. ARDEN: Mr. Serrano's prepared statement accepts harm to Meridian Community Supply Cooperative and does not qualify his apology. He recognizes that restitution cannot undo the diversion of community resources. His remorse is directed to the victim as well as to those who depend on him.

Since the offense, he has participated consistently in a structured, noncustodial treatment program. The exercise records show regular attendance, completed sessions, and a continuity plan. We are not placing a provider, diagnosis, address, or medical detail in the public transcript. The relevant point is sustained engagement rather than a last-minute promise.

Treatment does not excuse fraud. It supports a judgment that supervision, lawful work, and continued programming can reduce future risk without requiring a term above what is necessary. Mr. Serrano is prepared to comply with an appropriate treatment condition during supervised release.

The court has these facts in the sealed memorandum and final report. They are meaningful because sentencing is individualized. We ask that the sentence allow eventual return to the stable routines he has built while still imposing punishment and full financial accountability.

Defense Mitigation: Caregiving and Employment

MS. ARDEN: Mr. Serrano provides recurring care and transportation for an adult family member with limited mobility. Other people share the responsibility, so we do not claim that incarceration leaves the person without assistance. The disruption is nevertheless real and bears on the practical effect of different sentence lengths.

He has maintained steady lawful employment in a scheduling and inventory position. The employer is unnamed in this public record. Attendance has been regular, responsibilities have increased, and the exercise file reflects willingness to consider his return after release. The work does not involve claims processing or financial accounts.

These circumstances are not extraordinary exemptions from punishment. They show present structure, a lawful path forward, and obligations that reinforce compliance. Combined with category-I history, acceptance, treatment, and restitution, they support 24 months rather than a longer term within the adopted range.

The defense asks for no fine so available resources can be applied to the \$186,400 restitution obligation. We do not oppose a \$100 assessment or a supervised-release term up to three years with lawful, tailored conditions. Those components make the total sentence significant beyond the period of imprisonment.

Government Sentencing Argument

MR. IVES: The government requests 36 months, three years of supervised release, \$186,400 in restitution, the \$100 assessment, and no fine. Thirty-six months is inside the 33-to-41-month range and accounts for both seriousness and mitigation.

The offense was knowing and sustained from August through early November. It involved five participants and \$186,400 in false claims against a community cooperative. We will not describe mechanics in open court, but the duration and repeated decisions matter for deterrence.

The government acknowledges Serrano's category-I history, acceptance, treatment participation, lawful work, caregiving, and expressed remorse. Those considerations support a sentence below the top of the range. They do not, in our submission, warrant dropping nine months below the low end.

The court's role finding is limited, but it is meaningful. Serrano exercised supervisory responsibility over Pared for a defined part of the offense. A mid-range sentence reflects that additional responsibility without treating him as an organizer of every participant. Supervision can support treatment, employment, and restitution after release. No fine is appropriate because repayment should take priority.

Defense Reply and Close of Advocacy

MS. ARDEN: Two brief points. First, the 24-month request does not minimize the loss or the court's role finding. It asks the court to weigh the narrow scope of that finding and the unusually concrete post-offense structure shown in the protected record.

Second, the accepted adjustment changes the advisory range by nine to eleven months at the relevant endpoints. A variance can recognize that the interpersonal evidence was contested even though the court found the government's account more likely. The resulting sentence would still include custody, restitution, assessment, and years of supervision.

THE COURT: Thank you. Ms. Arden, is there anything else from counsel before I state my findings under § 3553(a)?

MS. ARDEN: Nothing further from counsel, Your Honor.

THE COURT: Mr. Ives?

MR. IVES: Nothing further.

THE COURT: I will proceed to the statutory analysis and sentence.

The court did not at this point address Mateo Serrano personally or invite him to speak. Defense counsel made no contemporaneous objection to proceeding. Serrano remained present beside counsel with a prepared statement that had not been delivered. The transcript continues directly with the court's sentencing analysis.

Section 3553(a) Analysis Begins

THE COURT: I have considered the nature and circumstances of the offense and Serrano's history and characteristics. The conviction involves knowing participation in false reimbursement claims, a three-month charged period, five responsible participants, and a stipulated loss of \$186,400.

The offense is serious because it diverted resources from a fictional community cooperative and involved repeated choices. No violence or threat is alleged. The public explanation does not depend on transaction mechanics or confidential identifiers.

Serrano pleaded guilty, accepted responsibility, and falls in criminal history category I. I have considered the protected mitigation concerning remorse, treatment progress, caregiving, and stable lawful employment. Those facts are genuine within this exercise and deserve weight. They do not eliminate the need for imprisonment, but they bear on placement within the advisory range and the conditions of supervision.

I have also considered the role finding. It is confined to management or supervision of Alina Pared for a defined portion. It does not describe Serrano as directing all five participants or organizing the entire conspiracy. That limitation informs the sentence I will select.

Deterrence, Protection, and Rehabilitation

THE COURT: General deterrence requires a sentence that communicates the consequences of sustained fraudulent claims. Specific deterrence is also relevant, though Serrano's lack of prior criminal-history points, acceptance, treatment, and lawful work reduce the need for a sentence at the top of the range.

The record does not suggest a violent danger. Protection of the public can be served through a substantial custodial term followed by supervision directed toward lawful employment, treatment continuity, truthful reporting, and restitution. Conditions should be no broader than necessary to support those goals.

Rehabilitation cannot determine the length of imprisonment, but the court may consider existing progress when evaluating the overall statutory factors. Serrano's consistent participation in treatment and stable work favor a sentence below 41 months. The caregiving category adds context without establishing irreplaceable hardship.

Restitution will remain a substantial obligation. I will not impose a fine because payment resources should be directed to the victim. The \$100 assessment is mandatory. These financial components and three years of supervision add consequences beyond imprisonment and help structure lawful reentry.

Consideration of the Competing Requests

THE COURT: The defense requests 24 months, nine months below the adopted range. That request would correspond to the bottom of the alternative range if the role objection had been sustained. I have not sustained it, and the three-level finding must be reflected in the initial benchmark.

The government's 36-month request lies inside the range and below its midpoint by a small margin. It gives meaningful effect to acceptance, category-I history, and post-offense progress while still accounting for duration, loss, and supervisory responsibility.

I do not treat the Guidelines as mandatory. I have considered whether a variance to 24 months is sufficient. On balance, it would discount the seriousness and the repeated nature of the conduct more than the mitigation supports. A term of 36 months is sufficient but not greater than necessary.

That conclusion does not depend on any sealed fact beyond the categories discussed in open court. It rests on the admitted offense parameters, the role finding, the advisory calculation, and the mitigation described by counsel. I will now state the sentence and then advise the defendant of rights that remain available subject to the plea agreement.

Explanation of the Selected Term

THE COURT: Thirty-six months reflects a middle position within the advisory range. It is above the defense request because the role adjustment applies and the offense caused a substantial stipulated loss. It is below the top of the range because Serrano accepted responsibility, has category-I history, and has made documented progress.

The sentence is individualized. I have not assumed that every five-person conspiracy warrants the same term, and I have not treated Serrano as managing participants other than Pared. The person-management finding is limited and receives proportionate weight.

The court has considered the need to avoid unwarranted disparity, provide just punishment, promote respect for law, afford deterrence, protect the public, and support needed treatment. Three years of supervision will permit continued programming and monitoring of restitution and employment. No fine avoids competing with victim repayment.

These reasons are stated in a public form that does not expose a confidential statement-of-reasons document or sealed personal history. The separate minute and reasons summary will likewise contain only public sentencing information. The court is ready to pronounce judgment on Count One.

Imprisonment and Supervised Release

THE COURT: It is the judgment of the court that Mateo Serrano is committed to the custody of the appropriate federal authority for a term of 36 months on Count One. Credit for prior custody, if any, will be determined under governing law by the responsible authority.

Upon release from imprisonment, Serrano shall serve three years of supervised release. He shall comply with mandatory and standard conditions stated in the written judgment. Any treatment condition will be administered without public disclosure of provider or clinical detail. He shall maintain lawful employment or approved constructive activity and truthfully report as required by supervision.

The court recommends placement considerations only at a general level and does not direct a particular institution. No authentic address, identifier, or designation is placed in this transcript.

MS. ARDEN: The defense notes its objection to the role adjustment and its variance request.

THE COURT: The objections and rulings are preserved in the sentencing record. The sentence is imposed after consideration of the advisory Guidelines and § 3553(a). I will next address restitution, assessment, and the absence of a fine.

Restitution and Special Assessment

THE COURT: Restitution is ordered in the amount of \$186,400 to Meridian Community Supply Cooperative. The written judgment will state the lawful payment framework without publishing any account or routing information. Payments during supervision will be adjusted according to ability and governing procedures.

The mandatory special assessment is \$100 and is due as provided in the judgment. No fine is imposed because the court finds that available resources should be applied to restitution. This ruling does not diminish the restitution obligation or lawful enforcement authority.

Serrano shall provide truthful financial information to Probation as required for supervision and payment administration. Protected financial material will not be reproduced in the public docket. The court has considered the parties' agreement on the loss figure and their common position against a fine.

MR. IVES: The government has no objection to those financial terms.

MS. ARDEN: Neither does the defense, subject to ordinary ability-based scheduling.

THE COURT: Today's lawful oral pronouncement will control if the written judgment contains a clerical difference. The clerk should enter judgment on February 25 after review of the standard conditions and financial language.

Conditions and Surrender Administration

THE COURT: Mandatory and standard conditions of supervised release will be included in the written judgment. A tailored condition may require participation in treatment approved by Probation, with confidential information handled according to law. Another may require lawful employment or an approved alternative, together with truthful financial reporting related to restitution.

The conditions do not authorize public release of treatment or financial records. They also do not restrict lawful activity beyond what is reasonably related to supervision. Counsel may review the written formulation before entry and promptly identify any clerical variance from today's oral sentence.

Administrative directions concerning custody or surrender will be handled through the fictional court channel and are not reproduced with addresses or security details. Serrano shall follow the clerk's lawful instructions. Nothing in this training transcript represents a real designation, reporting location, or date.

MS. ARDEN: We request that the record reflect continued access to prescribed treatment pending any custody transition.

THE COURT: Probation may coordinate that matter without placing protected details on the public docket.

MR. IVES: No objection.

THE COURT: I will now give the notice concerning appellate rights required after sentencing.

Rule 32(j) Appellate-Rights Notice

THE COURT: Mr. Serrano, subject to the terms of your plea agreement, you may have a right to appeal the judgment and sentence. Any notice of appeal must be filed with the district clerk within 14 days after entry of judgment. If you ask and qualify, the clerk will prepare and file a notice on your behalf.

The plea agreement contains a broad waiver of conviction and sentencing appeals, including Guidelines challenges, with an express exception concerning complete denial of the personal opportunity to allocute. I am not deciding the scope of any potential appeal in this notice. You should consult Ms. Arden promptly about the written judgment and any filing decision. Do you understand that timing advice?

THE DEFENDANT: Yes, Your Honor.

THE COURT: This advice occurs after sentence has been imposed. It is notice under Rule 32(j), not an invitation to address the court before sentencing. The clerk will provide the separate written notice to counsel today. Judgment is expected to be entered tomorrow.

MS. ARDEN: Thank you, Your Honor.

MR. IVES: Nothing further from the government.

Adjournment and Transcript Certification

THE COURT: Counsel, are there clerical matters concerning the written judgment?

MS. ARDEN: None at this time.

MR. IVES: None.

THE COURT: The sentence is 36 months of imprisonment, three years of supervised release, restitution of \$186,400, a \$100 assessment, and no fine. The clerk will enter the written judgment after confirming standard language. Court is adjourned.

THE CLERK: All rise.

The proceeding ended without Judge Venn personally inviting Mateo Serrano to speak before imposition of sentence. Arden's advocacy described his prepared mitigation but did not constitute his allocution. Serrano did not deliver his prepared statement, and neither defense counsel nor the government objected to the omission during the hearing. A preliminary exchange confirmed that Serrano could hear and consult with counsel but did not invite mitigation; the court's post-sentence personal address concerned only Rule 32(j) timing advice.

Tessa Wren certifies that this fictional transcript accurately represents the synthetic hearing recorded for DE37. It contains no real court audio, reporter record, presentence report, personal identifier, or operational description of wrongdoing. The certification records the hearing as it ended on February 24, 2026; it expresses no view about any later filing, remedy, or appellate disposition.